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Jamey Aebersold

Jamey Aebersold is one of the most influential early pioneers of jazz education. Since the late 60s he has produced play-a-long recordings and jazz theory books, and has organized summer jazz camps with noted artists as instructors. Jamey is an accomplished saxophonist and has been honored by the Jacobs School of Music at Indiana University and by the National Endowment of the Arts.

Jamey was interviewed via Zoom on September 26, 2022 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe for the Fillius Jazz Archive and I am extremely pleased to have Jamey Aebersold with me today. It's a privilege to chat with you, and kudos on your career.

JA: Thank you. Glad to be here. Looking forward to this interview.

MR: I love the look of your office, your music room, and I can relate to the LPs behind you. Are those mostly your productions or are they also jazz artists?

JA: They're jazz artists.

MR: Yes. Very lived in and worked in.

JA: Memorabilia to the max and I often call this room the "Jazz Smithsonian of the Midwest." I don't know what's going to happen to it when I die.

MR: That is a question for a lot of us, and there are certain places in the country who do accept donations but sometimes it's not as easy as it sounds. There's a lot to consider about accepting a donation and into the future, what happens with it. If I could I'd like to take you back a little bit. You were born and playing early on in the mid-50s is that correct?

JA: Yes.

MR: When you got in bands at that time can you remember what the songlist would have looked like? The repertoire?

JA: Yes. "In the Mood," "Tenderly," "Pennsylvania 6-5000" songs like that. I sold my song — I bought arrangements when I was in high school. I was probably 15 years old and we started this little group called The Nighthawks. So I would buy those arrangements for a dollar and a quarter that had four trombones, five saxes, trumpets, you know. And we cut those down and played them with two saxes and one trumpet and piano, bass and drums and maybe a trombone if we were lucky, and maybe a tenor sax if the local band director's son was free that day or that night. You know. But we started off playing what I now call the old standard from the Great American Songbook.

MR: And they've lasted a long time. Were you playing for dancers?

JA: Yes. Mainly dancers at the various animal clubs like The Moose and The Elks and The Lions. You know. Things like that. And then we played for sock hops at the high school. We played for various things but we played the same tunes kind of over and over, "Tuxedo Junction" comes to mind, "In the Mood," "Satin Doll" I think.

MR: Was there a point during this band's life where pop music like early Elvis, Jerry Lee Lewis, started to creep in and did you get requests for such things?

JA: I remember eventually playing "The Green Door," "I Ain't Nothin' But a Hound Dog" and then a little later "Tie a Yellow Ribbon Around the Old Oak Tree" or something. Now that's about it but I'll tell you, in the early 90s I just stopped playing — I stopped playing any job where they were smoking, number one. And number two I think the band leader that I was playing with, bass at one time, we played together for some years but he was branching out into what you're talking about and some country tunes and things. And he wanted to rehearse and I just said I can't do this. So I think I quit on the same day that he fired me. And we were still good friends it's just that that's not what I wanted to spend my time doing. You know. So I quit doing that. No but it didn't really infringe. That was in the 50s when we started so we made it way up into the 70s I think, still playing what we would now call standards.

MR: Did you notice that the income, what you could charge for the band, did it change over the years in relationship to the cost of living?

JA: Oh I didn't pay any attention to that. I was — I don't know it probably did but we never seemed to make much. You know I've got my books from the early years where we made three dollars and four dollars and five dollars and seven dollars. And if you played a New Year's Eve job and got thirty or forty or fifty bucks apiece that was a big deal. A big deal. So the money never really — I mean it was nice to get it but I never really thought about that.

MR: Why did you do it?

JA: Oh because I loved playing. I loved playing these tunes. I loved — I was usually the leader so I loved going down and taking my load of cardboard stands and setting them up at the VFW Saturday afternoon, putting the music out, you know what I mean? We didn't have a PA or anything. Didn't need one back then. But I got excited doing that, and then when we got through I tore everything down, came home, and paid the guys before we left and I'm still doing it only at a different level.

MR: So if you were playing "In the Mood" which has, the typical arrangement has the saxophone solos written out that we're so familiar with. Can you recall — were you playing saxophone with this group first of all?

JA: Yeah. I was playing alto.

MR: Do you recall the early times that you tried to play something that wasn't on the page?

JA: That was probably way before then. Way before then. I played piano from the age about five 'til six and took lessons and she fired me. She gave me my two dollars back one day and said, "Jamey you go on home, you'll never be a musician, you don't want to practice." And I was really tired of practicing those scales, four octaves, you know two hands. And had she asked me to improvise or do anything like that I think I'd still be playing the piano and I wouldn't have had to wander over to my brother's saxophone then clarinet and then flute and then when I got to school they didn't offer saxophone so I studied bassoon, oboe, clarinet, flute, yeah. And then I eventually took up the bass and I mess around with the guitar. But I would have been back on piano had she started me with improvising at an early age. So I think I was noodling all the time. But I can't really remember. And I'm sure I was noodling on my saxophone. And we did, when we played with The Nighthawks we would have little blues that we would play and we would all take choruses.

MR: Nice. Do you think that had something to do with the kind of kid you were? Did you have the personality of exploration?

JA: Oh yeah. You mean at a young age getting in trouble? Yes. The trouble was not bad. I wasn't letting the air out of neighbors' tires and stuff like that but I was exploring at an early age, yes. And I think it kind of moved over into music too, you know, messing around on the piano, messing around on the saxophone, writing out things and listening. But I was probably 19 or 20 years old before I really started thinking with the left side of my brain as to what I was doing and possibly what I wanted to do musically, and what they were doing on the records.

MR: Putting a bit of — trying to match a bit of music theory with what you were already doing. Is that correct?

JA: Yes. Yeah. I think that playing the piano and being able to read and play bass clef and treble clef and the simple tunes that I played really helped me later when I started playing a one line, single note instrument like the saxophone and then starting to write out arrangements for people. Because I could visualize it in my head. Whereas if I hadn't had that written page with the two things up there I don't think it would have been as easy to me to make up tunes and have the band play them.

MR: I believe writing arrangements, especially in those days where we did it with pen and pencil is one of the most complete learning experiences you can have.

JA: Oh yeah. Speaking of that, tell me if you can hear this [plays chords on piano]. Can you hear that?

MR: I can.

JA: That's my phone but I'm going to let it ring. That chord I found in school when I was in college and that's a C sharp 7 sharp 9 and that's something that Horace Silver played.

And I took it off and I was showing my friend one day. And Roger Pemberton, I've told this story before, but Roger Pemberton was giving us a two person arranging lesson. And He came in the door and I said, "Roger what's this?" And I hit that chord and without thinking he said, "That's a C sharp 7 sharp 9." And that just blew my mind away. I said, "Well how can you tell?" And he said, "Well it just sounds like it." And I silently moved it up to E 7 sharp 9 and hit it. And I said, "What if I hit that?" He said, "Well I'd say E." I said, "Roger, how can you do that?" And he says what you said which was he transcribed a lot of big band arrangements and wrote them down on those big pads of paper with a pencil and then copied all the parts. Well by that time I was standing up in the room and I asked him, "Roger you transcribe big band arrangements?" He said, "Yeah." Of course back then you couldn't buy them. You know Berklee School of Music hadn't started publishing. And that just blew my mind. So I told everybody at IU at the time, "Do you know what Roger can do? Roger can take any sound and tell you what it is." And of course that chord for me was the most complex chord I'd ever hit you know. So Buddy Baker, a trombone teacher and player who is still alive out in Greeley, Colorado, he told me to get a pitch pipe and start working on my intervals which I did, and the pitch pipe probably moved me a whole lot as far as being able to hear what I was playing in relationship to scales and chords and bits and pieces of scales and chords that all these professionals were playing on the records that I was listening to so that just the ability to be able to hear the intervals and to be able to identify them in people's solos I think for me, and I consider myself a very slow learner, so I was 19 or 20 before this started to kind of get started. I realized the scales are really important and I don't have them under control, and the chords are really important and these people that I've been listening to, Oscar Peterson for instance on the piano, they are not necessarily born with this ability to do this, they practice and they practice and they practice the same things that I've been working on for 15 years. But they're doing it in an improvisatory manner and that day that I noticed that Oscar Peterson was playing bits and pieces of scales at very fast tempos, a light came on in my head. They're not special. You know? And maybe if I work at it I can get to the point where I can play a decent solo. You know?

MR: Wow that's a great anecdote. Was there a point that you can recall now where you started to pass on to other people what you had — you know this light that came on for you and then you could pass it on?

JA: I've always been that way. You know if I find something that seems to work, the first thing I want to do is call my friend and tell him. You know or email somebody. Today I bought some instruments, there's a little music store downtown right across from the post office. And at 11:00 today they were selling everything in the store and they're going to go into just teaching, and fifty dollars for however much you can carry out. So I went in,

I was about the twentieth person to get in there. So I picked up a flute, a Selmer saxophone, a snare drum, something else, something else stuffed in my pocked, a mute, and this, that and the other, for fifty dollars. I checked it out and walked the half a block to my car and put it in the trunk, but on my way walking over there I was already thinking about it, going home and emailing my friends. There were some guitars left on the walls, you know? Maybe they'd like to come and buy a guitar for fifty dollars. Yes, as soon as I learn something I'm passing it on. So I've never been a hoarder in that respect at all. Yeah I'm always passing stuff on. As a matter of fact I have an email list which I probably ought to put you on. And some people say, "Jamey, gosh, you send too many emails." I say, "Well then block me" you know. But I don't send anything out unless I feel it's important.

MR: What were the saxophone players that you aspired to sound like, or isn't that a relevant question for you?

JA: Oh no, that's highly relevant. Gee. I listened to Ted Nash. Do you remember Ted Nash?

MR: Um hum.

JA: I think he's the uncle of the guy that's playing now. What's his name? Is it Ted?

MR: I think it's also Ted Nash.

JA: Yes, right. I think the one I listened to was his uncle or granddad. But anyhow I listened to him a lot and I had a quartet record from the Westlake School of Music out in California with a tenor, piano, bass and drums. And I don't know whatever happened to them but I played that over and over. I had an Oscar Peterson — excuse me — Oscar Pettiford record that I bought, and then I bought — my first LP — my first 78 was Duke Ellington on two sides. "Tootin' Through the Roof" was one of the tunes and I forget what the other one was, and then I bought a Kid Ory 78 and that was Dixieland. And then I liked those so much that I started — my dad had a florist and we lived just a block from where I live right now. And we lived right next to the florist. So I bought a record player and started buying records. The day after I read in some magazine that jazz was the coming thing. So this would be about 1950. I was probably ten years old or so. And I went down to the record store and bought a couple of 78s. And then I remember walking back in one day and the guy was getting to know me now, he said, "Hey Jamey, I've got something new." I said, "What's that?" And he shows me an LP. I said, "Wow, what is that?" He said, "Well they cost five dollars apiece." I went, "Oh." He said, "But you get 20 minutes worth of music on both sides. You know eight tunes. I said, "Oh." So then I didn't buy any more 78s. But I started listening and listening and listening to records. So when it came to saxophone players I heard Charlie Parker well I don't know what to think about him. And then there was Sonny Stitt, and then there was Sonny Rollins, you know and then there was all the other people that came along in the years later like

Wayne Shorter and Michael Brecker, etcetera, etcetera. But in the early stages I listened to all those people. And I also listened to trios, piano trios, bass players. I've probably got twelve, thirteen thousand LPs, maybe more than that.

MR: I must say that when you said Charlie Parker and I don't know what to think about that, if you see over my shoulder you see your "All Bird" book. When I bought that and tried to play along with it, I said, "I don't know what to think about this except I'm not ready for it."

JA: Let me show you something. You know musicians, we've always aspired to be able to play fast, fast, fast and being able to play what we're actually thinking at a fast tempo and make it swing, make it cook. Here's the fall of 1994, J.J. Johnson. I'll read it to you: I'll read it to you. He says, "Dear Jamey, Leaving for Japan in a few days. Chops are just awful. Thank God for Aebersold [he means the play-a-longs to warm up with]. Jamey, I really do appreciate you sending me all of the goodies. [that is, whenever a new play-a-long would come out I'd send it to him.] Well my fastest one, which was the emphasis was on playing fast was Volume 61 called Burnin' B-U-R-N-I-N-apostrophe. He says [holds paper up].

MR: Can you read that last part?

JA: Yeah it says "Burnin' long line well question mark, question mark, J.J." And I thought that was really cute.

MR: That's terrific and I'm glad you held on to it too.

JA: Oh yeah. Yeah.

MR: Let me ask you, I'm sorry, go ahead.

JA: That reminds me of a story. I was doing a clinic up at Youngstown, Ohio, probably thirty years ago, and I had some students playing the scales up to the ninth and back down and chords, and we may have played a blues or something. But it was rudimentary exercises. And I was packing up to leave 'cause a guy was going to drive me back to Pittsburgh in order to fly back to Louisville and do this all in one day. And a gentleman walks up to me, he looked like he was about 33 years old, and he plays the trombone. He says, "Jamey, playing those exercises is easy on the saxes and the trumpets and so forth but you can't play that way on a trombone." I said, "Oh you can't?" He said, "No. Nobody plays like that on the trombone. Fast." [scats] You know for instance. And I just happened to have a cassette of J.J. Johnson with Horace Silver and Woody Show and Joe Henderson in my — and I had a cassette player back then and I had that cassette. So I said, "Well here, you take this and play this first track over there." And they were playing "Nutville." Do you remember that tune?

MR: Um hum.

JA: "Nutville?" and J.J.'s solo is [scats] And I'm looking over at him and wondering what he's thinking. And we didn't really talk because I was busy packing up but I was thinking when I headed back to the airport, he's got a decision to make. He's going to start practicing or he's going to give it up. Because the trombone can play that fast.

MR: Let me ask you if, you went to Indiana University, correct?

JA: Um hum.

MR: And was there jazz — was jazz recognized anywhere like it is now when you went there?

JA: Oh no. They didn't offer the saxophone and neither did the Manhattan School of Music. Now that was 1957. I think maybe in 1958 or '59 they finally started the jazz band for I think a half a credit and you met three times a week I think. And Buddy Baker the trombone player was the leader of that. Yeah it took a while to get going and the practice rooms were at a place called East Hall, it was like a rectangle with a couple of rooms in the center but all the practice rooms on the outside, and he had a particular guy named Herb Shive S-H-I-V-E, and he took care of East Hall. And if he heard you playing jazz he'd come in and [shakes finger]. No jamming. "Hey! Break it up in there, no jamming." And this was 1957, '58 you know. And at that time people like Freddie Hubbard and Wes Montgomery would occasionally drive down the 40 miles from Indianapolis over to the Trees Center where you could get a hamburger and a chocolate shake every night you know like from probably from eight until ten or something, and they would come down and just jam. And I probably heard them, but I can't recall it.

MR: There's something for me that — it was a sort of similar at SUNY Fredonia but this was years later when I was there, that when students are pursuing something that the administration in the school doesn't do on their own, it's actually more special.

JA: Oh yeah.

MR: Like we really own it.

JA: Yeah.

MR: Students don't have that now, so I don't know if there's any conclusion about that because certainly jazz is part of almost all music school curriculums, but we'll get there. We'll come back to that. Did you have an aha moment, sort of an epiphany along the way about what you do? How did this launch, this idea of people can learn to improvise and I can help them?

JA: Yeah. I'm glad you asked me that because I have, the lady that helped me get this started, her — I think her address is over on my thing and I almost wrote her a letter. I've been waiting since — I've been waiting over 60 years to write her a letter. When I was in college I told everybody I wouldn't be a teacher because some of the students that I heard practicing in the rooms next to me and the recitals that I had to go to, I didn't think they played their instrument very well. So back then I was very naïve. I thought in order to be

a teacher you had to really play well, because you're going to be an example. So I told everybody I wouldn't be a teacher. But yet when I got up to about my fourth year, senior year, I was out in the parking lot, it might have been my junior year in the spring. And Gene Montooth comes up to me and he at the time had a goatee and he was what we would call a hippie. Played tenor, okay? Played oboe, maybe bassoon I can't remember. But he came up and said, "Hey Jamey, I've got a job teaching in the fall, high school. I've been teaching privately on Saturdays down at Seymour, Indiana, about forty miles from here at a music store. Would you like to take over that? Thirty minute lessons, you make two dollars a lesson, if everybody shows up you make twenty or thirty bucks?" I said, "Well," I'm thinking in my mind I told everybody I wouldn't teach but I real quickly justified private lessons is not really being teaching. So I said, "I'll take the job." So I started teaching and there was a doctor in town, Dr. Black, and he had two daughters and they both took lessons from me, but the older one, Susan, who I'm going to write, she played the flute and she played it much better than I did. Got a great sound facility and so forth. So at that time "So What," "Kind of Blue" by Miles Davis had been out two years. And I'd been experimenting with modal songs. So one day, there was a piano in the room, I said — thirty minute lessons — and we had about ten minutes to go. I said, "Susan, I want you to play me the D minor scale, no sharps, no flats, two octaves." So she goes [scats]. And I said, "Okay now I'm going to walk a bass line just give you a little background, you play whatever you want to play." And she instantly starts playing what she hears in her head. And I'd never done anything like this before. I never worked with a student before. I just worked with me and talked to my friends. So she starts playing and I'm playing and I'm playing and I'm thinking wow, she's playing exactly what she hears in her head. Just like speaking but she's never done this before. So we stop and I said, "Well let's take it up a half step." So we went up to E flat Dorian now. She did the same thing, 'cause she could play the flute. So right then my brain said wow, maybe anybody can do this if you show them the scale and give them a little background. So I didn't know it but that was probably the beginning of my play-a-longs.

MR: Terrific story. And I wanted to speak about "So What" actually but a little later. Now we've got two laters. So this developed into this idea of recording a piano trio and assembling what you felt was enough information to get people started. Did you have trouble in a couple of things. First of all do you recall if the piano trio had to do some adjusting because they weren't backing anybody up? They were just playing. Was that difficult for them at first?

JA: In the early stages I don't think it was because we all, none of us really knew what we were doing. We were trying to lay down some tracks and I probably told the piano player don't play too busy. And drummer, don't take a solo, delineate the form, eight bar

phrases, four bar phrases, whatever. And bass player, just walk. You know? And I don't even think we did any bossa novas on the very, very first one. I doubt it. They were probably all kind of swing. But later, once we moved in and you had people like Hal Galper who you've interviewed, and some other ones, they found — Ronnie Mathews on the piano up in New York. They found it a little difficult to just comp. Dave Brubeck comped on my Dave Brubeck play-a-long. And afterwards he said, "Jamey, that's the hardest thing I've ever had to do."

MR: I can hear him say that.

JA: Yeah. "Jamey, that's the hardest thing I've ever had to do." I said, "What's that?" He said, "Just to comp for five minutes like that." But yes, so on some of those early ones I would scat sing. I'd have a microphone you know [scats]. And that seemed to free up the piano player. And if you listen on that Volume Six behind you there, if you listen carefully you can hear me playing the alto because that was my sixth play-a-long and that was the first one that I flew to New York to do with Kenny Barron and whoever it was, Ron Carter and Ben Riley. Yeah. And I played in the room but it seeped in somehow you know.

MR: Well I can see how the keyboardist and the bass player could not intentionally but sort of zone out after a while.

JA: Oh yeah.

MR: There's — it's an interesting thing to have to do.

JA: Yeah, it is. And with some of the piano players I would say you can mix it up you know. Sometimes use like two hands but a little further apart, but then don't stay like that because you've got your solo stuff here in the higher register. Bring them back more into the middle. And another thing I would have to say too is after we'd get into the fourth or fifth minute of something and it's starting to cook, I mean it really is feeling good, watch it — piano player, don't get to soloing. Pull back please, relax. And of course sometimes the tracks would speed up a little bit and some of them I put out that way but then later I had Gene Perla the bass player, adjust them. So I've got certain volumes that I gave to him, three or four or five or six that rushed. But it's also interesting that when we recorded them originally we would have re-done them had we all agreed, that one rushed. But what we usually said was, "Boy that felt good." And then when I got the tape home I realized they rushed. So it taught me a thing about rushing. Rushing is okay if everybody agrees it feels good. But dragging is like dying. So if it drags you've got to stop and start over.

MR: And you had the foresight to put on tuning notes. Correct?

JA: Yes, yup.

MR: Because that was important in the days of vinyl and turntables.

JA: Yes.

MR: Because not everybody's going at the same rate.

JA: Yeah right, that's for sure. And I'll tell you, putting those LP records on — you remember these record players they used to have in every school, they were small, had a little lid, they were kind of gray.

MR: Indeed I still have one.

JA: Oh do you? What's the name of it? Is it Audio something?

MR: Audio something. Yes. I borrowed it from a local educational resource and then when I went to take it back they said, naa, you can keep it.

JA: Keep it, right. Well I used to have to take a chalkboard eraser because it would be going fast and I'd slide it up in order to bring the pitch down just a little bit when I'm out in Podunk and having the kids play-along with Volume 1.

MR: Oh that's priceless. Well you've had your share of technological changes and challenges because you've been in business so long. I recall the fellow that used to run Commodore Records talking about when 78s changed over to LPs and what a — it almost put them out of business because they had all this stock. How do you — did you see the CD thing coming?

JA: Yeah but we put it off for a while. Getting up the cassettes was good but the problem with cassettes were they didn't always run at the same speed. I don't know if you remember or not but let me just think a second — SONY had a cassette player. Yeah that's what it was. And it had a pitch control on it. Yes. And it was great for play-a-longs. It was a cassette player with a pitch control. But then I think they found out it probably cost them ten cents to put that on there but they found out that the only people that used it were jazz people playing with my play-a-longs, so they took it off. But the pitch has been a problem, especially with piano. But now like the CD player I have has pitch control on it you know, and our streaming that we have now, it has pitch and tempo control on them. Now I don't know if you know it or not but some of my play-a-longs, I think maybe eight of them, we some years back took them and slowed them down, the tempos. Kept the pitch the same, the key stayed the same but we slowed them down. And Charlie Parker is one of them. It now has two CDs. Volume 1 is one, Benny Golson has one, and a couple of others. I think there was about eight of them where we have slowed down CDs. Of course with the streaming you can slow it down automatically.

MR: So the accompaniments that came with the book that's over my shoulder, you took them and digitally they were able to be slowed down, is that correct?

JA: Yeah. Gene Perla, the bass player, did that. He and his friend. And they did it with half a dozen, six, seven, eight of my play-a-longs. And the ones that were rushing a little bit, he straightened them out. I can remember playing with Volume 34 like "Just Friends" [scats]

and then it gets a little faster after a couple of minutes, then it gets a little faster. But now when I play with it I'm waiting for it to speed up and it doesn't. It stays the same, which is nice of course.

MR: And when you talk about scales, have you come to a point where the type of scales that you put in books and recommend, is there a ceiling for that? And by that I mean I have bought, purchased books where they have scales whose names I can hardly pronounce. And I wonder at what point do you say I think we've gone far enough with scales?

JA: Well I think you'll probably agree with me, it depends on what tunes you're playing. I'm still playing tunes from the Great American Songbook and jazz classics, which of course is hundreds and hundreds of tunes. And those tunes, in my mind, you know if you're playing a major scale, unless you intentionally want to play outside. Let's say like a Michael Brecker might do or a Keith Jarrett or maybe a McCoy Tyner with the fourth thing that goes through there, like that and so forth. But the object seems to me, has always been tension and release, tension and release. And some of them can keep the tension going longer to the point where if I buy the CD if it's just me speaking I can't wait to make it through the last track so I can never play this CD again because they've gone out too far for too long. And I just — I can't hear any relationship to the harmony that somebody is trying to play beneath them. So I'm still basically back to major, minor, dominant seventh, half diminished, and on the major scale playing a Lydian scale raising the fourth, maybe raising the fourth and the fifth. When you get to the minor scale you've got your pure minor, which I hardly ever use, harmonic minor, melodic minor and Dorian minor all the time, plus, depending on the type tune you're playing you can play the blues scale, you can play chromaticism, and get your dominant sevenths, you've got a whole host of alternate scales to play. And I play a lot of those a lot of the time. And in my listening to records I find there are certain people that over a dominant they've maybe got two choices. But then when I listen to other people like a Michael Brecker, he might have three or four choices plus patterns they devise and chromaticism and sequences. So when he plays it could be more interesting or to someone who's not used to listening he could be disrupting to their ears see, they don't know what's going on. But as far as all the scales, books that come out, all different ones, I don't pay any attention to those because I don't hear that and that's not what I grew up with I guess. That's not to say that I can't hear and play new things.

MR: Are there mistakes in improvising for you?

JA: Mistakes?

MR: Mistakes.

JA: Yes. That's when the kids that I'm working with up at Park Middle School in Jeffersonville about five miles from my house — every morning from nine to nine forty-

five — I've been working with them for two months. Free, just to do it. Eight saxophones. Yes there are mistakes. And today Sebastian, he's playing his tenor and he goes [scats] I put on Volume 24, major and minor. We work with major, the B flat major scale. Today we worked with the B flat concert minor scale. We practiced the scale, practiced the arpeggio up to the ninth and back down. They couldn't have done this two months ago at all, not at all. Anyhow, when he was playing he went up and hit the major third, his C minor. He his an E but when he hit it he went — his eyes blinked and he lowered it a half step. And I stopped — I let him play it for a few seconds and then I stopped and I said, "Did everybody hear that?" And a couple of them, yeah. I said, "He's self-correcting himself." He hit a major third against a minor chord, which is one of the worst things for your ears to hear. But he heard it, and he wouldn't have heard it two months ago when we started. So I relax when Sebastian is playing because he can self correct. That's the way we all want to be. So that means you have to listen to what you're playing in relation to the CD that I brought in and the little speaker. So yes there are mistakes but not the kind you're talking about I don't think.

MR: Well thank you for saying that because I think mistakes or unintended notes — it may depend on who you're working with and what age. But I can see how Michael Brecker — people might write out, transcribe Michael Brecker's solos and point out that look he played a major third over a minor chord, and they will justify it. They will say it's a color tone or watch because he does it seven measures later. It's a bit of a conundrum I think. I was debating about whether to do this or not and I'm going to give it a try and get your opinion on something. This is a very small part of a lengthy analysis of a solo from a recent recording, a well known saxophone player published in a well known jazz magazine. And the scenario is it's a tune that has many unrelated chords, one thing followed by wow where'd that come from. I'll try to read through this fairly quickly. The idea is negotiating these unrelating chords by using common tones. So the person wrote: "His solo starts with this approach. The B flat, which is the sixth of D minor if we're hearing Aeolian scale is the fourth of the F minor nine and the E flat seventh of the F minor is the fifth of the G sharp minor. He's ending his lines on a note that fits both chords. It creates a forward motion effect while at the same time sounding almost modal. Then there's a lick over the bar line at measure 45. He plays the same minor interval across the bar line — I'm almost done — but the high G flat doesn't really fit the F minor 9. One could say that rather than resolving his line to the chord he's letting the chord change resolve to his line. Or perhaps he's just anticipating the chord change by half a bar.

JA: Well that's analysis and that's the left side of the brain taking over. I don't know — that sounds like something I've read before though, and there's been several things in JEN J-

E-N — Jazz Education Network — that I just actually wonder about and I kind of wonder how can this be helpful to someone trying to play a blues or trying to play a tune. I don't know. Maybe I'm still — maybe I'm still stuck back playing changes and maybe this person isn't. I don't know.

MR: It seems like they go to lengths to not acknowledge that people play things they don't necessarily mean to. And it's like we don't want to call them errors or mistakes, we're just going to come up with a way that somehow justifies that particular note. And I don't know what to say about that. Just like I didn't know what to say about the Charlie Parker.

JA: Yeah. You just reminded me of something. I took arranging in college from Bernard Heiden. Do you recall him? Composer? He was at IU. Anyhow we had several classes, two semesters of it, and he got to talking and analyzing the Bartok Fourth Violin Sonata I guess it was. Okay. So as soon as class was over I ran up to the IU library and got the record out, put the headphones on — well we had a book. It was in the book. You had to buy the book, the score. And the way it was — the twelve tone — this way and this crest over here and down below this and the next page it was going this way and it came down and passed — I thought visually and intellectually hearing him talk about it and describe it, it was fantastic. And I knew this was going to be better than listening to Charlie Parker. So I went to the record and listened to it. It sounded — and I still think this today about my experience then, I played it two or three times, watching. It sounded like about four garbage men emptying the garbage. I didn't know what to think. Because my eyes and my intellect told me this was a fantastic piece of work and for someone to write it out and then have it played, they must be great, and it must sound good. Boy it didn't sound good to my ears. Not then anyway. Yeah so what you just read, I don't know what to think. I don't know.

MR: I wonder how you would feel if someone transcribed a solo of yours and, well it's hard to speculate — but I do recall that Sonny Rollins recorded that song "Blue 7" and Gunther Schuller picked it apart and kept, you know, look how Sonny is inverting what he played twelve measures ago and the whole thematic development thing, and what I read was that Sonny Rollins was very intimidated afterwards and felt like oh I shouldn't do that anymore.

JA: Oh. Now I didn't hear that but what I heard was Sonny Rollins said he would never read another review by Gunther Schuller. And then later I read that Sonny got over that. But I got the magazine. I forget what was the name of it, that had that solo in there. And I can remember being in college, buying it at the bookstore and opened it up and there's that solo I've listened to dozens of times. It's a classic solo. It's embedded in my brain you know. For me nowadays to play a solo and to bring out something four minutes later, after the drum solo that I played in the first or second solo, I measured up to Sonny

Rollins. I mean I'm not as great as Sonny but I did what Sonny did you know. Well I remember seeing that solo in the book thinking — my first thought was this is fantastic. Because Gunther Schuller did all the work and here it is you know. And I wondered what Sonny was going to think of that and of course he didn't think much of it. He thought — he thinks like say Hal Galper thinks, and that is if you can hear it you can take it but I'm not going to give it to you. I'm not going to write it down for you. Kids at the camp. "Hal, how'd you do that? Did you record it?" "No. Well find somebody to record it and take it off. I'm not going to tell you." You know there's that wall between [da-da-da-da-da-da] But Sonny Rollins was a classic and that record, CD, I still have out in my van. And I'm going to listen to it Wednesday on the way down to Bowling Green, Kentucky. And that "Blue 7" solo is fantastic. And the Max Roach and Doug Watkins and Tommy Flanagan I think on piano. That record made a big impression on me.

MR: How do you get the students you're working with now to do what that very first student you had, you related that incident with the D minor and the E flat minor, and she's poking on the piano and playing legitimate improvisations. Is there a way to teach the idea of playing what you hear?

JA: Yes there is and I think starting off with the simple scales, one or two like the Dorian minor scale is one of the best places to do — also I ask some students to sing with a microphone and then play. Sing — play. Any more, I just have to use myself as an example because I think all the pros have done it. They're playing what they hear in their head. But in order to do that they've practiced and practiced and practiced so their instrument will cooperate with their mind. Now Wednesday when I go down to UK, Western Kentucky University, I will probably — I have 55 minutes. So I don't have much time. And I hope a lot of students come. I don't know how they billed it. If they billed it as a jazz thing then there won't be very many there. But I really would like for everybody to come. And what I will do, maybe at the beginning of the thing, is ask for a volunteer. Okay? So someone is brave, they come up and I give them a mic and I say, "What instrument do you play?" And they tell me. And I'll say, "Well I want you to sing." And often times they go, "Awf, I can't sing" you know. I say, "No, this is going to be easy." So they take the mic and I play on the piano just slow things like this, and I ask them to sing. I say, "You can just go la-la-la or whatever you want to do." [plays piano]. Just like that. Playing chords slowly, bossa nova like. And they start to sing. Most times they sound great. They pick out the sharp fours on some chords, they play sharp nines and flat nines as leading tones. They're always landing on roots, thirds, fifths and sevens. And then when we come down at the end I'll come down chromatic like, major chords, two beats apiece, their voice goes right with me. Then I put a little 2-5-1 and then maybe I come down starting on the tri tone and come down slowly and their voice just follows

me and on the end everybody applauds. And then I say, "Do you have any idea what key we started in?" "Oh no." "What key did we end in?" "I don't know." That note you sang at the ending, was it a sharp four over a major chord?" But I don't tell them that, I say that was the prettiest note you can play over that. Do you know what that was? No. And I give them a Duke Ellington quarter anyways. One of the state's quarters. The Washington, DC quarters is Duke Ellington, did you know that?

MR: No I didn't.

JA: Yeah okay. So I give them one of that. And then I tell them, the audience, I say, "This person, man or woman, boy or girl, what you just heard was the real them. He plays the clarinet. Could you play that on your clarinet? No. So that doesn't tell us that he can't improvise. What it tells us is he hasn't worked hard enough on the clarinet to get it to copy what he's hearing in his head at the instant he hears it. He wasn't singing all kind of eighth notes and triplets and runs and such. He was singing quarter notes, half notes, whole notes, but the notes he was choosing were chosen by his mind, and that's where my "Anyone Can Improvise" comes from, incidentally. But you can't necessarily do it on your instrument unless you practice. And that's what these eighth graders I've been working with every day and we're getting close to four weeks now and today we played B flat minor with my Volume 24 CD and I learned something today. And that was — well maybe it's because we've been working on things gradually every day for four weeks. But today we ran the scale and then I said, "Let's do the triad" [scats] and then the seventh chord, then the ninth chord. And then we did the ninth chord backwards and they caught on really quick. And I noticed when they started soloing, eight bars apiece, some of them started up on the ninth. As soon as they hit that ninth my brain said, "Man that sounds nice" you know? And they kept it going. Yeah. So yes, I thing the scales and the chords can be taught and I'm trying to get them to play what they hear in their head. And it's slow going, but we've only been at it two months, you know, eight weeks. Barely eight hours.

MR: Do you have to, do you find it necessary to try to explain and/or demonstrate the difference between swing and straight, or do they do it pretty much because of the way the song sounds?

JA: Yeah. That's a good question. They have not listened to any jazz at all but I will say this, the first time I put a CD on the baritone player and Sebastian, the tenor player next to him, they're snapping on two and four. And today they were doing that while everybody was soloing, even though it was a bossa nova. So they can feel this music. And when we start to play, going back a month, they tongued everything. So I had to tell them to stop tonguing, play legato. And of course I had my sax and I would demonstrate it. And they seemed to be picking things up. Now I haven't said "Don't tongue" in a long time. I said

it today when we did the minor scale, just to be safe 'cause this was a new scale and they're having trouble figuring the lowered third and lowered seventh. But they all sound pretty good. And we played a blues last week and they — but they're not swinging. Well I guess they were swinging, because two adult teachers came in the door and were smiling, "Hey what are you all doing?" I said, "We're trying to swing." "Well it sure sounds good out here to us." Which I'm sure made the kids feel good. But we haven't really entered into the swing yet because we haven't played — it's just not there yet.

MR: You said the next — this upcoming engagement you're going south for, you made this little aside saying I don't know how they're going to bill it. If they bill it as jazz no one will come.

JA: If they bill it as jazz then there'll probably be twelve or thirteen jazzers there. But the violins won't come, the oboes, the trumpets that don't [inaudible] in the orchestra. This jazz thing, Monk, is still really scary to so many people. Oh it's just — and it's so silly because I can get them playing in no time at all. I was with somebody the other day who is a professional and his playing doesn't swing. Okay? But he doesn't really play swing stuff but there was someone playing with him that I know and he was talking to me about this fellow's playing. And I told him, I said, "Well if I could somehow get together with this fellow for an hour I think I could straighten him out, because there are certain things in his lines that are not proper. The phrases aren't ending right, even though he's an adult and has been playing for a long time." When I hear him play it's all detached like. And I've discovered how to un-detach it and make it singable and make the phrases go like that. And if you start that early, which I'm trying to do with these kids, then I think it's going to — once they ever decide to get into it and start practicing — hey that's another thing. I told their teacher a week ago I said, "These kids are not practicing at all. I'm wasting my time." Next day I come to class, I get there early. We've got a little gym room and chairs and stands are all set up. And I get in there, I'm in there ten minutes and I look at my phone, what's going on? I said uh oh, she is giving them a lecture about practicing. Not the eight kids, but the eight kids and the other forty kids that are in the eighth grade band. I walk in and sure enough, she's really a good teacher. So this past weekend, just now, Lillian, Lilly, the girl, saxophone player, she said, "I practiced an hour and a half on Friday." Hallelujah. You know? And the little boy over here said, Xavier, he said, "I practiced two and a half hours over the weekend." He's been into it. He's the only one with the CD player so I gave him Volume 1 and I gave him Volume 54, and I gave him Volume 24. He's practicing.

MR: Have you ever tried a classical sounding accompaniment and having people, having students play as if J.S. Bach was improvising?

JA: No but I've been doing it and I'd love to play something for you. May I?

MR: Certainly.

JA: I've been working on this for a while and it's totally improvised. Let's see. And it's really — sometimes when I play it it sounds like [scats] and then other times it sounds like [scats]. And all of a sudden I've moved a couple of centuries ahead.

[musical interlude]

I've got hearing aids and that sound to me just sounds awful.

MR: It doesn't sound awful here. And I have a hearing aid too.

JA: Do ya? Yeah. Well it sounds awful to me and that really stops my creativity.

MR: Yes. You know it reminded me a little bit of the Swingle Singers.

JA: Oh yeah. Yeah.

MR: Now you said you lost your place, so what was the place? Did you have chords in your head?

JA: Yes. Yeah. And I went from that note to the next one but it was a minor third instead of a fourth, so I lost where I wanted to go. And I've been practicing. Let me just see if I can just relax the sound and act like it sounds good.

[musical interlude]

I love that phrase.

MR: Yeah.

[musical interlude]

JA: See I'm playing and I know what happens, I revert back to my teenage years, which is oh I can play that. But as soon as I play that second note that's not the note I was hearing then I have to think. Think, think, think. Use the left side of the brain. Think, think, think, think, think until you get it memorized, 'til you get it under control, and then you don't have to think. And I've said that to people so many times, but I still need to say it to myself.

MR: Well I wish I had a — let's see — thirty dollars for every time I've asked the question to jazz musicians, what are you thinking about when you play, and the answer is, "I'm not."

JA: Oh. Well I'm thinking.

MR: I think too. Maybe their definition of thinking is different from mine but I still am at the point where if I'm playing a standard, improvising on a standard, I'm thinking about the chords as they're going by.

JA: Yeah. I am too. I've had a few instances, not very many, where I actually play something and it might be like a major or six beats or possibly two measures long where I'm not consciously thinking. And when that passes and I'm still playing, I'm thinking back on that. Boy that was neat. And I think at times I also think is that what these people are saying when they're not thinking? You know. But it's just automatic? If that's the case

then I've still got a whole lot of playing to do to get to the stage where I consistently play without thinking.

MR: Well congratulations by the way on your NEA Jazz Master.

JA: Oh yeah. That was a surprise.

MR: '14 wasn't it? 2014?

JA: 2014, yeah. When he called to tell me about it I thought he was a salesman and I almost hung up on him, and then I realized oh, golly, he's serious. Then I told him, I said well have you run out of people to give this award to? I really was thinking well they've hit the bottom and they're calling me. Incidentally, I've got two of those tee shirts and I still wear them when we go out and do school concerts and so forth, just letting them know that our government, there's a certain portion of it, even though it's small, appreciates music and jazz, you know? And they want jazz to be put out there. Boy I wish NPR would stop playing that garbage, techno music they play between their stories.

MR: Yeah it's a shame that jazz has almost zero presence on television and cable. I mean you have to go out of your way to find it. But I've been trying to formulate a question, I'm not successful yet, but it seems like jazz has had different roles and exposure in American society and it's changed a lot. I haven't figured out what the role of jazz is today, in today's world.

JA: I don't think it has much role.

MR: But it's ironic that I just got the last *DownBeat* issue and it's the sort of where to go to school issue. And it's hundreds, literally hundreds of schools, and they're just the ones that decided to put an ad in the *DownBeat*. So if it doesn't have much of a role, why is it that it's been so elevated and embraced by academia?

JA: Well I think academia needs money, they need people to come to school, and jazz has been, over the last sixty years, very popular with young musicians, this, that and the other, and the question has always been well if you graduate these people and they can play jazz what are they going to do? Because there's never been enough opportunities for everybody to play. So I don't know what they do. They seep over into doing other things and maybe they teach privately and maybe they play two nights a week instead of five, and maybe they play two times a month instead of ten. I'm not sure. I'm not sure. I don't know. But I will say this, and I came home from my class today with these eighth graders feeling this way. I'm right. I'm right. These people can improvise, and once you get them improvising, even on a simple scale, they get excited. Now we haven't got to the stage where I've been able to play some — I played Charlie Parker for them one time and I gave them the first page of "Now's the Time" solo. Okay? Which is way over their head. But I gave it to them and we listened to that, and we listened to one or two choruses of Hank Mobley playing "This I Dig of You." This was several weeks ago. But you only

have about forty-two minutes. So I really need a listening class. That would help these people to appreciate it more, I know. But back to your question, academia and jazz — I don't know. I just don't know. I don't know. You don't hear it out. Here's something I'd love to do. I'd love to get somebody with a whole lot of money and if we go to McDonald's and Wendy's and all these fast food places and say I will pay all of your BMI, your Muzak funds for five years. Three years. You don't have to pay. You're paying thousands of dollars a year, I'm going to pay it. I'm going to dictate what music you're going to play and I'm going to give you some samples, and you're going to play jazz. You're not going to play "Giant Steps," you're going to play Bill Evans and Oscar Peterson, trios, and we're going to play people playing ballads and blues and swing stuff but not fast. Maybe some big bands, maybe not. And we're going to put that into your system and we're going to contract us for five years. At the end of three years I know you would tell the difference. People would go there for the music. Now, my wife and I go out to eat quite a bit because she can't really cook anymore. And yesterday we were at a place in Louisville called Freddy's. We drove fifteen miles to get there. And it seems today every restaurant we go in has to have at least one or two screaming kids [imitates child screaming]. Now I will say I don't think Freddy's had any music, but there are some places where the music is just awful I think. But jazz used to be played you know. I think Panera still plays jazz possibly. But academia and jazz — I think the people running the shows, the deans and so forth, they were never taught to improvise and they still think of jazz as being special, over there. And they admire the jazzers because they know their theory, they can play their theory and they can play with music, they can play without music, they're a total musician.

MR: Yeah and most of them can go and fill a spot in the symphony orchestra too.

JA: Exactly. Exactly. Sure can, yeah. But still we don't know what to do with them. We don't know how they do what they do. I think every college, freshmen coming in, the first semester they all have to take an improv class. They have to learn to play "Mary Had a Little Lamb," "Happy Birthday," this, that and the other, learn the blues, play the blues scale, play on Volume 24 major and minor, take those scales and put them to use.

MR: This has been fascinating, Mr. Aebersold. And I am privileged to talk to you and as I said kudos for what you've done. Do you have any other — you're still doing it, and do you have any other specific projects that you're contemplating?

JA: We're working on our streaming. We presently have our tracks but they can't be played on Apple phones and so forth, and it's a little cumbersome to use although we have quite a few people using it, all right? But we're getting real close. As a matter of fact today was supposed to be the day that we were going to launch with about twelve friends of mine and have them work out the thing but I had a problem with it the other night. So it's

going to be easier to use, it will have tempo controls, and have access to about 2,000 tracks. They can have, if you're playing "Now's the Time" you can play it with piano, bass and drums, or piano and drums, or bass and drums. The only thing you can't turn off is the drums. So they choose which instrumentation they want and then they can speed it up, slow it down, change the key. So I think this is going to bring in a much wider audience. Of the eight people that I've been working with at school only one has a CD player. Three of them I think listen to Spotify. The others don't listen. That's the impression I get. And of course they don't listen to jazz. But after this class that we're having every day I'll bet some of them will start listening.

MR: Have you ever run across someone that you had multiple encounters with in teaching and you decided well I found someone who can't improvise?

JA: There's a couple of kids in this class that are just struggling, but I don't even think we've gotten to the point of improvising. I'm just trying to get them to [takes deep breath] take a good breath, support their tone and play the scale. I don't think they're scared to death, they're just fumbling to play the instrument. But everybody else, no I've never found anybody that can't improvise. I do remember one person years ago, I was doing my two-day workshop and this guy comes up to me on a break, I'm setting up the piano. And he said, "Mr. Aebersold, I'm tone deaf." I said, "Oh you are?" "He said, "Yeah, I'm tone deaf." I said, "Well let's see." So I hit a note and he doesn't hit that note. He sings something else. I hit another note, he doesn't sing that note. I said, "Okay, here we go. I'm going to hit the note, and you think about it. Don't open your mouth until you think you've got that note." So I hit another note. Just keep thinking. I hit the note, just keep thinking. And finally he very faintly goes, "Laaaaa." And it happened to be the note. And I hit it again and I said, "Are you sure?" "Laaaaa. I think so." "What is that? I don't know if you're listening." "Laaaaa." I said, "Guess what?" He said, "What?" I said, "You're not tone deaf you're just not thinking. And then we played other notes, we played other notes and he got them. I said, "So you can't say that anymore. Forget that. You're not tone deaf." So sometimes it's a quick thing like that that I hope changes somebody. That's like — I know you want to close here but I'm down to the post office today and I come outside, here's a fellow leaning over talking to two people in the car and he's smoking. And boy can I smell the smoke and I hate smoking. And then he leans back about six feet and kind of leans against the pole. I walked past him and I could smell the smoke all along here. So I go and get a — I don't have one in front of me here, a quit easy stop smoking book that I published. I printed 50,000 of them and I'm giving them out. Okay? I have one in my van. So I went over and got it, I walked back up and he looks at me and I said, "I've heard your cough before and I've smelled that smell before. Have you ever thought about quitting?" And he says, "Well yeah I have." I handed him

the book and he says, “Thank you, you’re a nice man.” And I walked by. That reminds me, this tone deaf guy, you know I’m doing this, this guy’s smoking. I came home and told my wife and I said but — she said, “Do you think it will help?” I said, “This guy? The way his lungs sounded when he coughed may be past the point of recovery if he were to quit.” Because it was the worst cough I’ve heard in a long time. You probably don’t know but I’m an anti-smoker.

MR: Well thank you for this time, Mr. Aebersold, you’re a nice man.

JA: Well you’re nice too, Monk, and thanks for having me on.

MR: All right. I’m just going to pause here and we’ll say our good-byes.

JA: Okay I want to show you something.

MR: Yes please do. Volume 1 All right.

JA: It’s Volume 1, yes. And it’s made its way to China.

MR: The other side of the world and they have their Jamey Aebersolds.

JA: Right. And this is how I got started with play-a-longs.

MR: Look at that.

JA: This one and this one. In the mid-50s.

MR: Hold on. I have to get into the cupboard here, if I can find it.

JA: Ah. Now I haven’t seen that one.

MR: Yeah this goes way back. It wasn’t a play-a-long it’s just that they would publish the sheet music.

JA: Well is that different than sheet music?

MR: It’s just popular songs with articles and it cost ten cents.

JA: Yeah. Ten cents. Hey well I enjoyed it.

MR: I enjoyed it too.

JA: All right. Thank you. You let me know when it’s up.

MR: I will indeed.

JA: All right.